

YANG FANG

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Computational communication; Social Science of AI; Generative Agent-based Modeling; Multimodal Analysis; Gender Studies

EDUCATION

Fudan University (QS#30), Shanghai, China

Sept 2024 – Jul 2027

- M.A. in Journalism & Communication (*academic degree program*) | GPA: 3.72/4.0
- Supervisor: Prof. Zhou Baohua (Director of the Computational and AI Communication Research Center)
- Core courses: Data Mining and Analytics (A); Journalism & Communication Research Methods (A-);
- Master dissertation: Can LLMs Improve Online Deliberation of Controversial Public Issues? An Exploratory Empirical Study Based on the Interest-vs-Value Framework

Communication University of China (211), Beijing, China

Sept 2020 – Jul 2024

- B.A. in Journalism (Data Journalism) | GPA: 3.86/4.0 | Rank: 3/43
- Core courses: Basics of Statistics (96); Advanced Mathematics (99) | Communication Effects: Empirical Approach (93); Social Science Research Methodology (87) | Web Crawling and Data Processing (96); Data Visualization – R/D3/Tableau (97); Fundamentals of Database and Access Applications (88); Web Design and Production (99)
- Bachelor dissertation (**Distinction**): Media and Audience Preferences: The BBC's Visualization of China's Image on Twitter

Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, Amsterdam, the Netherlands

Feb 2026 – Jul 2026

- Exchange courses: Experimental Design and Data Analysis (R); AI & Society: Fixing Algorithmic Decision Making; Social Robotics

PUBLICATIONS & CONFERENCE PAPERS

Tian, Y., Bao, Z., **Fang, Y.**, & Zhou, B. (2026). "It's okay to withdraw, I'm here for you": AI sycophancy, interpersonal conflict guidance, and individualization of sociality. *Computers in Human Behavior* [**Under Review**]

Fang, Y. (2026). Ruling in miniature: Computational aesthetics and visual propaganda in 1960 Soviet and Chinese postage stamps. *National Communication Association (NCA) Annual Convention* [**Under Review**]

Fang, Y. (2026). Does my suffering have a name? A computational text analysis of Chinese political depression discourse on X. *International Communication Association (ICA) Annual Conference* [**Accepted, oral presentation**]

Zhou, B., & **Fang, Y.** (2025). Advances and prospects of computational international communication research in the era of large language models. *International Communications, (04)*, 48–52. [**Published**]

Fang, Y. (2023). What makes gender-based violence a (less) prominent issue? A dynamic analysis of network agenda setting based on the China Restaurant Assault. *International Association for Media and Communication Research (IAMCR) Annual Conference* [**Accepted, oral presentation**]

DISSERTATION

Can LLMs Improve Online Deliberation of Controversial Public Issues?

Master's Dissertation in Fudan University, 2025-2026

An Exploratory Empirical Study Based on the Interest-vs-Value Framework

- Investigating whether matching LLM-mediated intervention strategies to different conflict types (interest-based/value-based) can improve the quality of online deliberation on controversial public issues.
- Developing two AI-mediated (interest-based/value-based) intervention strategies grounded in social conflict theory and deploying them via a purpose-built experimental platform with threaded interface to simulate an online deliberation context (Govers et al., 2024)
- Designing a 2x3 factorial experiment (issue type x mediation strategy) to examine main and interaction effects on deliberation quality, operationalized as reasonableness of talk, cross-opinion interaction, and comprehension of opposing views (Medaglia & Zhu, 2017)
- Collecting user-generated comments and scale responses and applying LLM-based annotation and computational text analysis to measure deliberation quality indicators

Media and Audience Preferences:

Bachelor's Dissertation in Communication University of China, 2024 (**Distinction**)

The BBC's Visual Construction of China's Image on Twitter

- Examined systematic visual bias in BBC World's selection and presentation of China-related images on Twitter, and its alignment with global audience aesthetic preferences.
- Extracted low-level visual features (e.g., clarity, brightness, saturation, color composition) from 2,071 news images using computational aesthetics methods (OpenCV, SciPy).
- Modeled the relationship between visual features and user engagement (likes, retweets), incorporating topic modeling (BERTopic) and sentiment analysis (BERT) as controls via regression analysis.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Human-AI Interaction in Public Communication and Political Participation

Jan 2025 – Present

Research Assistant | Ministry of Education Humanities and Social Science Fund | Supervisor: Prof. Yu Tian

Remote

- Built a full-stack experimental Chinese/English platform (Node.js/Express, SQLite, Server-Sent Events) that supports parallel data collection under 12 experimental conditions, real-time GPT-4o response streaming, and condition-specific CSV export for downstream NLP analysis and performed prompt-engineering.
- Experiment 1: Examined whether GPT-4o exhibits sycophantic behavior when users seek emotional support (vs. practical advice) for everyday problems; manuscript submitted to Computers in Human Behavior
- Experiment 2: Examined how AI identity disclosure and gendered persona design (neutral/male/female) shape users' political participation across four partisan issues; and engineered system prompts to ensure balanced stance across partisan issues

Political Depression as Affective Infrastructure: A Computational Analysis

Oct 2025 – Nov 2025

Independent Research | ICA 2026 | Political Communication Division

Shanghai, China

- Using X as an alternative affective infrastructure where political expression suppressed on censored domestic platforms can surface, examined how political depression manifests as a distinct affective phenomenon in the Chinese context
- Constructed a corpus of 2,979 Chinese-language tweets on political depression (2019–2024); applied BERTopic (multilingual MiniLM embeddings, Jieba tokenization) for topic modelling, GPT-4 multi-label emotion classification across 27 categories (GoEmotions taxonomy), LIWC cognitive analysis, and Google Perspective API toxicity assessment

Computational International Communication in the LLM Era

Jan – Mar 2025

National Social Science Fund of China (NSSFC) Talent Program | Supervisor: Prof. Zhou Baohua

Shanghai, China

- Conducted a systematic review of 54 studies on LLMs in international communication research and proposed a four-paradigm typology (model as object vs. method × comparative vs. flow perspectives international studies)
- Identified persistent Western-centrism in both cultural and political focus of LLM international communication research; called for more explanatory studies and greater standardisation and transparency in model parameter settings and prompt design

Gender Issue Salience in Media and Public Agendas: A Longitudinal Network Agenda-Setting Analysis

Jan – Feb 2023

Independent Research | IAMCR 2023 | Gender and Communication Section

Beijing, China

- Compiled a dual-source corpus (310 newspaper articles + 10,137 Weibo posts) divided into three Issue Attention Cycle stages; applied BERTopic to identify 26 thematic attributes and mapped network agenda structures via UCINET 6 (degree centrality, core-periphery analysis); verified cross-source agenda transfer using QAP correlation
- Tracked the striking decline of gender issues in the public agenda and the strengthening NAS effect, revealing how media agenda-setting colludes with social power order to suppress gender-based violence framing

DATA PRACTICE PROJECT

Cross-National Aging Inequality: A 60-Year Data-Driven Visual Narrative

Sept 2024 – Jan 2025

Data Collection and analysis, Interactive Visualization & Web Development | Fudan University | airrhead.github.io/retirement-delay

- Harmonized 60-year demographic data (World Bank, UN DESA) for 206 countries; built scroll-driven visualizations (D3.js, Scrollama, ECharts) including animated choropleth maps and unit charts;
- Processed 19 national retirement policy documents (1949–2024) using GraphRAG with locally deployed Qwen2-7b-instruct to construct a knowledge graph of policy evolution

Market Survival in China's Indie Game Industry: A Data-Driven Interactive Feature

Mar 2023 – Aug 2023

Data Collection, Simulator Design & Web Development | National Excellence Award | airrhead.github.io/Indie-Game

- Scraped 1,695 Chinese indie games from Steam; derived a survival rate formula from real revenue distributions and built a data-driven social simulation (JavaScript, Swiper.js) with randomised events drawn from developer interviews

SKILLS

Computational Methods: Topic modeling (BERTopic, LDA); LLM-based annotation(text and multimodal); sentiment analysis and emotion classification (BERT, GoEmotion, Text2emotion); toxicity analysis (Google Perspective API); network analysis (QAP, UCINET 6); computer vision (OpenCV, SciPy); GraphRAG; LIWC

Survey & Quantitative Methods: Large-scale survey design (PPS sampling); SEM/AMOS; OLS regression; experimental design (factorial, between-subjects); web-based experimental platform development; fsqca

Programming & Tools: Python; R; Node.js/Express; SQLite; API request; SPSS; D3.js; ECharts; Scrollama; Flourish; Tableau; HTML5; web-based experimental platform development

Languages: Chinese (native); English (IELTS 6.5)